about things of no significance, about trying to organize protests of affairs on the campus, and so on.… The meetings were interminable.” Bohm left the party after several months, but he remained a Marxist in his political convictions for many years afterward.

Bohm’s politics presented a problem for him when it came time to defend his PhD. Despite the fact that Oppenheimer had personally requested that Bohm be transferred to Los Alamos, Bohm had been denied security clearance by the Army. Army security lied to Oppenheimer, telling him that Bohm was a security risk because he still had relatives in Europe that could be used against him; in reality, Bohm had been denied clearance because of his association with Weinberg, who was also a member of the Communist Party. But Bohm’s thesis research, on interactions between atomic nuclei, was nonetheless very relevant for the work going on at Los Alamos—so much so that it was immediately classified beyond Bohm’s clearance. His notes and calculations were seized by the Army, and he was forbidden from writing his own thesis. Oppenheimer swooped in to the rescue, assuring the UC Berkeley administration that Bohm deserved his PhD.

Bohm continued on at Berkeley for a couple of years after the war, publishing papers on various recondite areas of quantum physics. In 1947, on the basis of that work and a favorable interview report from John Wheeler, Princeton’s physics department hired Bohm as an assistant professor. “Bohm has been recommended to us as one of the ablest young theoretical physicists that Oppenheimer has turned out,” wrote Henry Smyth, the chair of the department. (Several years later, Smyth would write of “stockpiling scientific manpower.”)

Bohm found Princeton’s campus and climate a disappointing change after his time in Berkeley, and he thought the faculty there were “very status conscious.” But Bohm quickly settled in. He started teaching quantum physics classes using Oppenheimer’s old notes and began research collaborations with several promising graduate students. He formed a small group of close friends and even struck up a relationship with Hanna Loewy, the stepdaughter of a professor at the Institute of Advanced Study. Bohm’s relationship with Loewy soon turned serious, and there was talk of marriage. Loewy brought Bohm home to meet her mother, Alice, and her stepfather, Erich Kahler. Bohm also met one of Kahler’s closest friends: